

“If a woman has had **more than one** husband in this **life**, she will be **free to choose** the one whose **character** she found **worthiest** to be her **husband in the afterlife**.”

LEBANESE PROVERB

Burial practices were—and still are—informed by customs and religious beliefs, and therefore differed for men and women. For example, Muslim ritual specifies that women are wrapped in five *kafans* (plain cloths) for burial, whereas men are wrapped in three (as a living woman is covered more than a man). Such differences in grave goods, burial positions, and inscriptions help archaeologists determine the gender of the dead and hypothesize about women's lives, but this method is now used with caution, as it is not consistently accurate.

Marking mourning

In Western societies during the 19th century, the period of mourning was governed by a rigid dress code. This reached its peak with the “widow's weeds”—all-black clothing—popularized by British Queen Victoria after the death of her husband in 1861. Women wore full mourning dress for a year, then half-mourning for another two. The color women wore lightened during half-mourning, changing through gray, mauve, and white. Female mourning dress symbolized a family's status and respectability; being able to afford the jet black silk of widow's weeds, black accessories, and the various changes of colored clothing was an indication of wealth.

In other cultures and times different colors have been used to signify mourning. White was a popular choice, worn by French queens in the 16th century (known as the *deuil blanc*) and is still worn today by Cambodians, who regard it as a color of rebirth. Color remains important in today's practices. For example, Aboriginal Australian widows wear white plaster caps to signify their mourning, with the thickness showing the level of grief. In

Papua New Guinea, widows paint themselves with gray clay and don layers of necklaces that they remove as the mourning period progresses.

Attitudes to mourning vary worldwide, depending on cultural beliefs. For as many as 3,000 years, Mexicans have celebrated the lives of their ancestors in rituals that became the three-day Day of the Dead festival from October 31 to November 2, when family and friends gather to remember the deceased. Many women dress as La Catrina—a modern incarnation of the Aztec death goddess—reflecting their comfortable relationship with death.



“**Rain comfort** on the throne! The **Royal Widow, strengthen** as **each hour doth roll**; her **mental anguish** cease ...”

MOURNING SONG FOR PRINCE ALBERT, 1862